what Mehta had been telling Goheen behind closed doors, i.e. active Soviet intervention in Afghanistan would only destabilise the region, and was not in Indian interests.[93] In the wake of Taraki's coup, Goheen, with orders from then US President Jimmy Carter, began pushing India to reassure Pakistan on the Afghanistan situation by accepting Islamabad's proposal for a pact to ban nuclear weapons, and explicitly commit to the 'principle of national integrity and the inviolability of established national borders', namely the Durand Line.[94] According to the US, there was evidence that Taraki would revive the Pashtunistan and Baluchistan issues once he had a better grip over his government.[95] Mehta appreciated the US and Pakistan's concerns about the Afghan coup, but was unconvinced by Goheen's argument that Taraki would reignite the Pashtun and Baloch issues given Afghanistan's economic woes.[96] Instead, he was more worried about such anxieties developing into self-fulfilling prophecies.[97] Mehta countered that reaching any precipitous conclusions was inadvisable, and that India recognised governments in Kabul without any regards to ideology. Since the PDPA's revolutionary council seemed to be in total control, there was no reason for New Delhi to delay recognition to the new government.[98] If anything, India's engagement with Taraki would only have a moderating influence on Kabul. Mehta's rebuttal to Goheen (this specific conversation occurred in May 1978) contrasted with those of I. P. Singh, the then joint secretary on the Pakistan-Afghanistan-Iran desk, in September 1978. Singh had been warning Goheen of China's support for a communist insurrection in the northern Badakhshan province (in the wake of Sino-Soviet tensions),[99] and increasing Soviet intervention in Kabul's internal affairs, which could only lead to a Pakistani counteraction. 'Afghanistan was not Czechoslovakia' where Moscow could intervene without a strong reaction, Singh warned the US.[100] Goheen was surprised by Singh's candid views, and construed them as a marked 'switch' in the MEA's perception about Soviet intentions in Afghanistan.

Despite apprehensions, there was no real switch in India's policy approach either towards the Soviet Union, or towards Afghanistan. India's reliance on the Soviet Union on issues relating to Afghanistan, in fact, was nearly total. Thus, when a coup by Amin brought Taraki's political career to an abrupt end on 14 September 1979 (and forced Sarwari to escape Kabul in a sealed container with a